EXPLORING

BEIJING

Your Ultimate Journey Through the Heart of China



• EMPERORS, HUTONGS & HIDDEN GEMS •

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BEIJING TRAVEL GUIDE
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OF 14

BEIJING 北京



Welcome to the Northern Capital

Beijing 北京 (*Běijīng*) literally means **"northern capital."** For most of the last eight centuries this has been the seat of China's emperors and governments, and it shows: golden palace roofs, grey-brick lanes and glass towers all share the same skyline.

It is a city to explore slowly — one gate, one courtyard and one bowl of noodles at a time.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS

The Vibe:
Grand, proud and surprisingly relaxed — imperial history with a modern heartbeat.

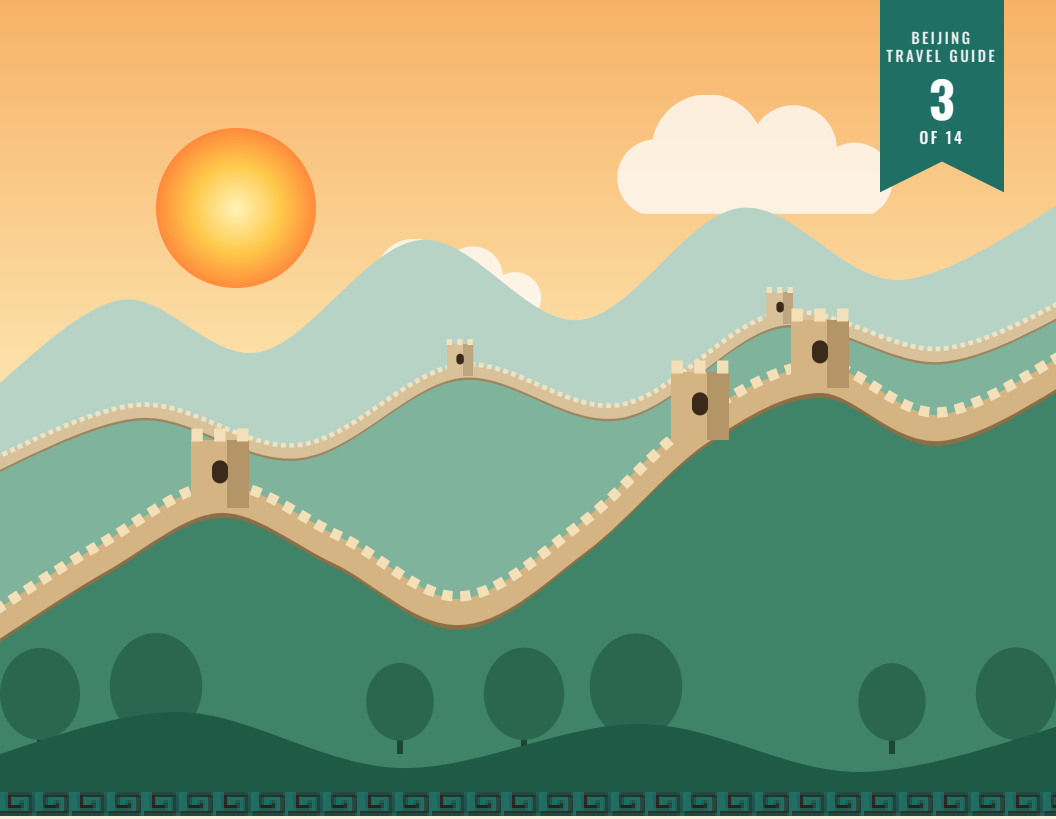
Best Way to Explore:
On foot and by bicycle through the hutongs, and by subway everywhere else.

Goal of this Guide:
To help you feel the soul of the city, from the Great Wall to a street-side breakfast.

BEIJING AT A GLANCE

The first city to host both the Summer (2008) and Winter (2022) Olympics.

22M	3,000+	8	2
PEOPLE	YEARS OF HISTORY	UNESCO SITES	OLYMPIC GAMES



长城 · CHÁNGCHÉNG

Dragon of Stone: The Great Wall

长城

No trip to Beijing is complete without standing on the Great Wall. The sections north of the city were rebuilt in stone and brick by the **Ming dynasty**, snaking along mountain ridges like a sleeping dragon. Each one offers a different mood — choose the one that fits you.

BADALING
八达岭

The most famous and best restored. Easy to reach, but busy.

MUTIANYU
慕田峪

Fewer crowds, forested views, a cable car up and a toboggan down.

JINSHANLING
金山岭

Wilder and quieter — the favourite of hikers and photographers.

QUICK FACT · DID YOU KNOW?

All the walls built by different dynasties add up to **21,196 km** — more than half the distance around the Earth. And the old saying is a myth: the wall **cannot** be seen from space with the naked eye.



故宫 · GÙGŌNG

Inside the Forbidden City

For almost 500 years ordinary people were forbidden to enter this palace. Built between **1406 and 1420**, it was home to **24 emperors** of the Ming and Qing dynasties.

Today it is the Palace Museum: about **980 buildings** on 72 hectares, all aligned on Beijing's north–south Central Axis.

STEP-BY-STEP ROUTE

1. **Meridian Gate 午门**
   Enter from the south, as officials once did.
2. **Hall of Supreme Harmony 太和殿**
   The largest hall, where emperors were crowned.
3. **Imperial Garden 御花园**
   Old cypress trees, rockeries and pavilions.
4. **Jingshan Park 景山**
   Climb the hill behind for the famous rooftop view.

COLOUR CODE

Look up! **Yellow roof tiles** were reserved for the emperor, and **red walls** stand for good fortune. Legend says the palace has **9,999½ rooms** — half a room fewer than heaven's 10,000.

天坛 · TIĀNTÁN

Heaven & Harmony: Temples and Gardens



TEMPLE OF HEAVEN 天坛

Here emperors prayed each year for a good harvest. The round **Hall of Prayer for Good Harvests** rises 38 metres on three marble terraces and was built entirely of wood, **without a single nail**.

Come at sunrise: the park fills with locals practising tai chi, singing and playing cards.

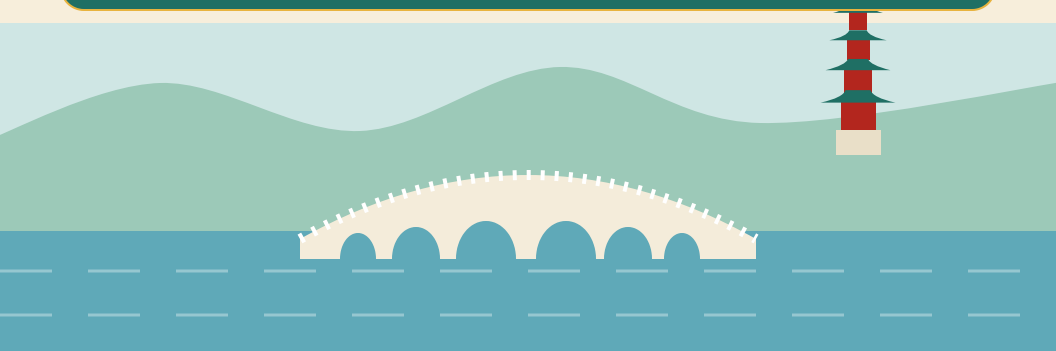
SUMMER PALACE 颐和园

The emperors' lakeside escape from the summer heat. Stroll the **Long Corridor** — 728 metres of painted beams — cross the Seventeen-Arch Bridge and find the famous **Marble Boat**.

Kunming Lake covers about three-quarters of the gardens. In winter it freezes into a giant skating rink.

DID YOU KNOW?

Round and square: the temple's halls are **round** and their bases **square**, because ancient China pictured heaven as round and the earth as square. Whisper at the **Echo Wall** and a friend far along the wall can hear you.





胡同 · HÚTÒNG

Old Beijing: Hutongs & Culture

Step away from the wide avenues into the **hutongs** — narrow grey-brick lanes lined with courtyard homes called 四合院 ***sìhéyuàn***. Neighbours play chess on the doorstep and songbirds sing from cages in the trees.

Wander **Nanluoguxiang** 南锣鼓巷, circle the lakes of **Houhai** 后海 and listen for the old **Drum and Bell Towers**.

EXPLORATION TIPS

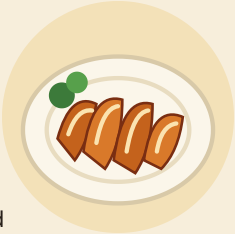
1. **Look at the doors**
   Stone drums, door studs and red couplets once showed a family's rank and wishes.
2. **Remember these are homes**
   Keep your voice down and always ask before taking photos of people.
3. **Catch a show**
   See Peking opera 京剧 (Jīngjù) or sip jasmine tea in a traditional teahouse.

LOCAL SECRET

Rent a bicycle or hop on a pedicab at dusk — when the lanterns come on and dinner smells drift out of every courtyard, the hutongs are at their most magical.

北京味道 · BĚIJĪNG WÈIDÀO

Taste and Reflect: The Flavour of Beijing



Beijing food is hearty northern cooking: wheat instead of rice, roast meats, noodles and dumplings. Every dish tells a story of emperors and cold winters.

MUST-TRY LOCAL DELICACIES



Peking Duck
北京烤鸭
Běijīng kǎoyā

Crisp, glossy roast duck carved at the table and wrapped in thin pancakes with spring onion and sweet bean sauce.



Zhajiang Noodles
炸酱面
zhájiàngmiàn

Thick wheat noodles tossed with rich fried soybean-paste sauce and fresh cucumber. Beijing comfort food.



Jianbing
煎饼
jiānbing

The breakfast of the city: a hot crêpe with egg, herbs, chilli sauce and a crunchy cracker, folded to go.



Mutton Hotpot
涮羊肉
shuàn yángròu

Paper-thin lamb swished in a copper pot of bubbling broth, then dipped in sesame sauce. Perfect in winter.



Dumplings
饺子
jiǎozi

Boiled parcels of meat and vegetables, eaten with vinegar. Families make them together at Chinese New Year.



Tanghulu
糖葫芦
tánghúlu

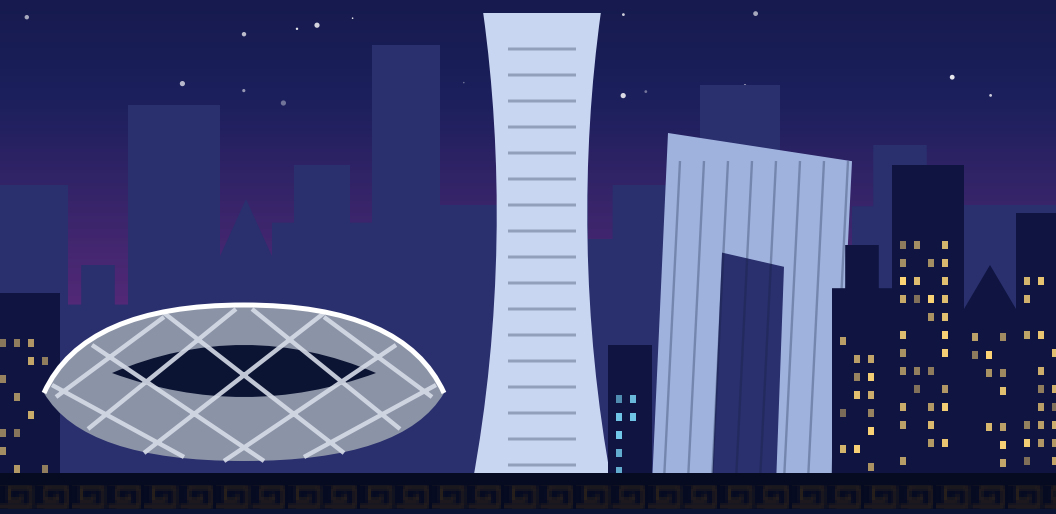
Skewers of hawthorn berries dipped in clear, crackling sugar — the sweet and sour taste of old Beijing.

TABLE MANNERS

Say **“好吃！”** (*hǎochī*, delicious!) to make any cook smile. Never stand chopsticks upright in rice — it resembles funeral incense.

现代北京 · XIÀNDÀI BĚIJĪNG

Tomorrow's Capital: Modern Beijing



Beijing is not only ancient. Since the 2008 Olympics it has become a showcase of daring design, with bold new landmarks rising beside the old palaces.

BIRD'S NEST 鸟巢

The National Stadium of the 2008 Olympics, wrapped in a tangle of steel "twigs." Stunning when lit at night.

WATER CUBE 水立方

The bubble-skinned swimming centre next door; it became the "Ice Cube" for curling in 2022.

CHINA ZUN 中国尊

At 528 m, the tallest tower in the city. Its curved shape copies an ancient bronze wine vessel.

CCTV HEADQUARTERS 央视大楼

A giant folded loop of glass and steel that locals jokingly call "the Big Pants."

798 ART DISTRICT 798

A 1950s factory complex reborn as galleries, street art, design shops and cafés.

DAXING AIRPORT 大兴机场

A starfish-shaped mega-airport opened in 2019, designed by Zaha Hadid Architects.

NIGHT OWL TIP

Walk the Olympic Green after dark for a free light show, then head to **Sanlitun 三里屯** for cafés and shopping.



公园 · GŌNGYUÁN

Beyond the Walls: Parks, Hills and Tombs

When the city feels too big, do what Beijingers do: head for the trees. Imperial gardens and forested hills are only a short subway or bus ride away.

香山

Fragrant Hills *Xiāngshān*
Hillsides that blaze red and gold with autumn leaves every October.

北海公园

Beihai Park *Běihǎi Gōngyuán*
A thousand-year-old imperial garden. Row a boat around the White Dagoba.

十三陵

Ming Tombs *Shísānlíng*
The valley where 13 Ming emperors rest, reached by a road of stone animals.

景山

Jingshan Park *Jǐngshān*
A small hill with the best sunset view over the Forbidden City's golden roofs.

QUICK CHECKLIST FOR HIKERS

- [x] Pack plenty of water, sun protection and snacks.
- [x] Check the weather and air quality before setting off.
- [x] Wear shoes with grip — old steps are steep and uneven.
- [x] Carry your rubbish out and respect wildlife.

读万卷书，行万里路 "Read ten thousand books, walk ten thousand miles."

交通 · JIĀOTŌNG

Moving Through the City: Iconic Transit



Getting around is an experience in itself. The **Beijing Subway** 地铁 (*dìtiě*) is one of the largest metro systems on Earth, with more than **800 km** of track. Signs and announcements are in Chinese and English, and a ride costs only a few yuan.

Above ground, join the river of bicycles. Shared bikes wait on every corner and the old city is wonderfully flat.

Leaving town? **High-speed trains** 高铁 race to Shanghai — 1,318 km away — in about four and a half hours.

WAYS TO TRAVEL

Subway 地铁
Fast, cheap and clearly signed. Avoid 7–9 am and 5–7 pm rush hours.

Bicycle 自行车
Unlock a shared bike with a phone app and explore the hutongs.

Two airports
Capital (PEK) in the north-east and Daxing (PKX) in the south.

TRAVELLER TIP

Get a **Yikatong** 一卡通 transport card, or set up a mobile payment app, as soon as you arrive. One tap works on subways and buses across the whole city.

四季 · SÌJÌ

When to Go: Seasons & Festivals

Beijing has four sharply different seasons, and each one changes the city completely. Whenever you come, there is a festival, a flavour and a view to match.

SPRING
春 chūn
MAR – MAY

Blossom in the parks and mild, breezy days. Bring a light jacket.

SUMMER
夏 xià
JUN – AUG

Hot and humid with sudden rain. Start early and rest at midday.

AUTUMN
秋 qiū
SEP – NOV

Clear blue skies and red leaves. The best season to visit.

WINTER
冬 dōng
DEC – FEB

Cold and dry. Fewer crowds, frozen lakes and hot pot weather.

♥ FESTIVALS WORTH PLANNING AROUND

春节 Spring Festival
Chūnjié · Jan / Feb
Chinese New Year. Temple fairs 庙会 fill the parks with lion dances, snacks and red lanterns.

元宵节 Lantern Festival
Yuánxiāojié · 15 days later
Glowing lantern displays and sweet rice balls end the New Year season.

中秋节 Mid-Autumn Festival
Zhōngqiūjié · Sep / Oct
Families share mooncakes and admire the full moon over Beihai Park.

国庆节 National Day
Guóqìngjié · 1 October
Flowers and flags fill Tiananmen Square. Expect big holiday crowds all week.

BEST TIME TO VISIT

September and October bring the famous “Beijing autumn” — dry air, golden ginkgo trees and deep blue skies. Just avoid the first week of October, when all of China is on holiday.

说中文 · SHUŌ ZHŌNGWÉN

Speak Like a Local: Survival Mandarin

Beijing is the home of standard Mandarin, 普通话 (***Pǔtōnghuà***). Even a few words will earn you big smiles. Read the pinyin aloud and watch the tone marks.

你好
Nǐ hǎo
Hello

谢谢
Xièxie
Thank you

请问…
Qǐngwèn...
Excuse me, may I ask...

多少钱?
Duōshao qián?
How much is it?

太贵了!
Tài guì le!
Too expensive!

我要这个
Wǒ yào zhège
I would like this one

地铁站在哪儿?
Dìtiězhàn zài nǎr?
Where is the subway station?

厕所在哪儿?
Cèsuǒ zài nǎr?
Where is the toilet?

不要辣
Bú yào là
Not spicy, please

很好吃!
Hěn hǎochī!
Delicious!

我听不懂
Wǒ tīng bu dǒng
I don't understand

再见
Zàijiàn
Goodbye

THE BEIJING "R"

Beijingers love to curl the end of words with an **"-r"** sound, written 儿. So *nǎlǐ* (where) becomes **nǎr**, and *yìdiǎn* (a little) becomes **yìdiǎnr**. Try it — you will sound like a true local.

三日游 · SĀN RÌ YÓU

Three Perfect Days: A Sample Itinerary



DAY 1 帝都
IMPERIAL HEART

MORNING	Tiananmen Square 天安门广场, then walk north through the Forbidden City.
AFTERNOON	Climb Jingshan Park for the rooftop panorama; row a boat in Beihai Park.
EVENING	Peking duck dinner, then a stroll along Wangfujing 王府井.

DAY 2 长城
THE GREAT WALL

MORNING	Early start for Mutianyu. Ride the cable car up and hike between watchtowers.
AFTERNOON	Toboggan down, then stop at the Ming Tombs on the way back.
EVENING	Warm up with mutton hotpot in a copper pot.

DAY 3 胡同
LOCAL LIFE

MORNING	Sunrise tai chi at the Temple of Heaven; jianbing for breakfast.
AFTERNOON	Summer Palace lakeside walk, or galleries at the 798 Art District.
EVENING	Cycle the Houhai hutongs and see the Bird's Nest glow at night.

PLANNING TIP

The Forbidden City is **closed on Mondays** and tickets sell out — book online in advance and bring your passport, which is checked at the gate.

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一路平安 · YÍLÙ PÍNG'ĀN

Final Checklist & Bon Voyage

- [x] Valid passport and the right visa for China checked.
- [x] Transport card or mobile payment app set up and ready.
- [x] Comfortable walking shoes packed — you will walk a lot.
- [x] Forbidden City and Great Wall tickets booked in advance.
- [x] Translation and map apps downloaded for offline use.
- [x] Layers for the season, plus water and sun protection.
- [x] A few Mandarin phrases practised: 你好, 谢谢, 再见!
- [x] Camera or smartphone charged for capturing memories.

一路平安



You are now ready to experience Beijing beyond the surface.

CHINESE PBL · PREPARED BY

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